

Where HCI Meets the Spiritual Path: The Three Yogas of the Bhagavad Gītā

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ABSTRACT

HCI practice can be a force for social good, but can it become a spiritual practice? If so, how? These questions are somewhat taboo, and usually discussed quietly at the fringes of the HCI community. This paper is based on the Bhagavad-Gita, and proposes three ways to tie-together a practical HCI career with our spiritual lives. The three approaches are broadly related to humanitarian action (karma yoga), love and devotion (bhakti yoga) and introspective insight (jnana yoga). Each offers a different perspective on our HCI practice, and how the practical challenge of being a researcher can be reframed as part of a spiritual path. It suggests approaches to issues such as emotional burnout and bias-awareness. It is based on teachings given by major Indian teachers.

CCS CONCEPTS

• HCI theory, concepts and models; • Psychology; • Social and professional topics;

KEYWORDS

Spirituality, Philosophy, Yoga

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1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Meeting Points of HCI Practice and Spirituality

There are little moments of beauty and wonder in the life of a user researcher. In the quiet moments before a user study, when the lab is clean, set and ready for the participant to enter. When an interviewee has laid out their life and shown you a complex fabric of experience you had never imaged existed. When your mind sees a bigger pattern at work, and an analysis snaps into focus letting you draw the meaning of the data into the palm of your hand. And there is a special beauty, too, in long team meetings where it seems unlikely that any decision will be made: it nudges us to wonder, does anything ever really happen? Or are we colorful glass

beads rotating in a kaleidoscope, perpetually repeating similar-yet-different experiences, project after project in a strange technosamsara? When we have lost track of the point of what the team is discussing, we might half-dreamingly sense the strange, unique beauty in each team mate, and somehow feel deeply satisfied. These are just some of my moments. Readers will surely have their own.

Questions about who we really are beneath it all, what is really going on with life, what is genuinely real, and what to do about it – these are questions that draw on our spiritual worldview. But we are not much trained or supported to think about HCI practice and spirituality in the same breath. This paper emerged from the need to find ways to think about HCI and spiritual practice together, and do so in an action-focused practical way. Especially during periods of personal and social tension – such as 2020 has been for most of us – it is important to reflect on what is truly meaningful in one's work. This paper suggests three approaches to finding connections between one's practice and spiritual life.

The three approaches described in the main body of the paper are based on the Bhagavad Gītā (normally called simply 'Gita' and pronounced 'Geeta'). This short text is one of the core scriptures of Indian spiritual culture, and thus a treasure of world literature. It has been taught internationally, and in the Euro-Western world for over a century by luminaries such as Swami Vivekananda (1863-1902) who spoke at the Parliament of the World's Religions in 1893, Paramahansa Yogananda (1893-1952), Sri Lanka Prabhupada (1896-1977) and Mata Amritanandamayi (b.1953) and many others. They teach it as principles for living that can be adopted by anyone, and something practical that can be experienced if one uses the methods. Many readers will be familiar with Yoga, and though the Gita does not deal with physical postures, it deals with Yoga in the sense of ways to connect our complex outer lives to something greater. Though I was not born in India, this has been the major spiritual framework of my life, and the context in which I study with my most influential mentors, and I will do my best to share my limited understanding of what those authorities teach (and I intentionally do not add new interpretations) and show how it connects to HCI practice (where I will share my own observations).

Worked examples, illustrations and case studies are helpful, and unfortunately space allows only a limited exploration of how to put it into practice. In a sense, this paper can at best whet the appetite or encourage further exploration. The performance concept for this Alt.CHI paper will have people describing how they personally put it into practice. The enduring advice for learning this material is – just as it would be if you wanted to learn to swim or play the flute – to engage in a friendly community of practice, learn from good teachers, and apply their advice.

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1.2 Language and Terms

The paper is intended to be accessible to an international audience who is unfamiliar with the Gita yet ready to be sympathetic towards it, so there are many references throughout the paper for digging further. A minimum of technical language is used, and the diacritical marks used in Romanized Sanskrit, e.g. for long vowels and retroflex consonants, have been omitted for ease of reading e.g. आत्मन् – ātman – is rendered simply as “atman”; गीता – Gītā – as “Gita” (pronounced “Geeta”), and कृष्ण, - Kṛṣṇa - as “Krishna”.

1.3 Background and Motivation

A brief description of my background and motivation will help situate and outline the scope of this paper. For about twenty years I have had the privilege to work as a UX/HCI/HCD researcher with a wide range of teams and in different industries, in the UK, USA, and India. I have also trained graduates and professionals in HCI and HCD at major universities and corporations. In parallel, from my teens, I have followed a deep interest in Hinduism, and have endeavored in its meditational practices – though I make absolutely no claim to have reached any form of enlightenment. On the contrary, even though I had studied and practiced for twenty years, in the mid-2010s I was diagnosed with a severe depression. Much of this I attribute to the accumulated effect of keeping myself split: openly a driven tech-professional, but in the closet as a spiritual-aspirant. Barely able to function, I resigned my role at a major US tech firm and put myself into a long retreat at a small, family run temple in the Bhakti Yoga tradition, set in the Redwood Mountains. The combination of the kind support of the community, the effectiveness of the ancient spiritual practices, and the “do or die” attitude that my suicidal mood aroused, was profoundly healing.

I was able to return to work about a year later, this time based in a leading humanitarian technology team in India, working on issues like women’s empowerment training, Human Robot Interaction (HRI) for rural India, disaster response technology, and digital educational tools for oral-culture communities. For me, the need to find some harmony between my day job and my spiritual life is an issue with consequence, and I am deeply grateful for the Amrita University team to have given me a place to contribute.

My experience in India let me work alongside people who showed a tremendous natural buoyancy and ability to stay bright, poised and effective even when working where there is extreme human suffering. My thought was: this is spirituality in action, and if the Gita’s principles enable them to do it, I must keep learning.

1.4 Brief Introduction to the Gita

The Gita is a short dialogue between Sri Krishna and the warrior Arjuna, set in the middle of a battlefield, moments before the start of a vicious war between two clans. Over about 700 stanzas, written in mostly very accessible prose, Arjuna expresses his despair and confusion in the face of the battle. Sri Krishna answers him, exhorting him to engage bravely with the complexity, yet in a way that will allow him to transcend the whole drama, and find freedom. The Gita itself is considered the quintessential scripture of Vedantic philosophy – which itself represents the essence of Vedic wisdom.

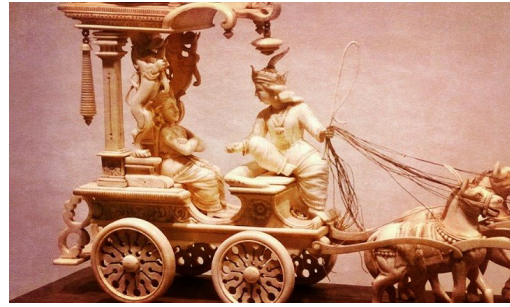


Figure 1: Sri Krishna addresses Arjuna. Sculpture in the Indian Museum, Calcutta. Photo by author, 2015.

Aldous Huxley describes it as “one of the clearest and most comprehensive summaries of the Perennial Philosophy ever to have been done.” ([1] p. xiv)

Yet it is a small set of chapters within the much larger Mahabharata epic. The details of Vedanta philosophy are lightly touched on in this paper, as are some of the dramatic themes of the Mahabharata [2] – yet a fuller account is outside the capacity of this author and the needs of this paper. The reader is referred to the excellent translations and detailed commentaries on the Gita by Paramahansa Yogananda [6], Swami Chinmayananda [1], Swami Anubhavananda [4], Srila Prabhupada [5], Swami Vivekananda [6], and others, each of which brings a different emphasis.

The Gita itself sits within a body of spiritual literature that is millennia-old, and has a wide variety of living practice lineages and commentarial traditions. It is a truism to say that there are many ways of understanding and relating to it. It is worth noting that there are more devotionally-oriented approaches [5] that do not so easily lend themselves to our purpose here because they are intended more for people living in or around a temple dedicated to Shri Krishna. Although the *bhakti* movement has profoundly influenced me, it is not the focus for this paper.

The intended audience for this paper is people who relate to the challenge of integrating their HCI work with their inner spiritual lives, and who are open to hearing about how the principles in the Gita might help with that. The starting point of this paper is that the principles of the Gita are effective, and its view of the human condition is accurate. This is not to deny other presentations of spirituality at all (and it is not my intention to suggest “one true way”). But nor will I try to prove it or justify it. Nor will the paper address the complex socio-political issues of religion, in India or elsewhere, such issues of inequality. This paper takes an appreciative rather than deficit-centric view of the topic, since our aim is to foster a generous discussion on how HCI practice and spiritual life might connect, and we need to approach both sides in their strength.

1.5 Spirituality in HCI

Spirituality and science easily cause destructive interference: the moods and mores of one contradicting the other. This can create problems for an HCI practitioner who feels allegiance to both sides, and who feels reluctant to split themselves. Loyalty to scientific method requires rationality and willingness to abandon faith-based

arguments. Critical social-science briskly deconstructs authority, hierarchical power-structures and gender roles. There are good reasons it is a topic kept at arm's length. HCI has inherited this ambivalence. In "Do we care about diversity in HCI?", a meta-analysis published in 2019 showed that "Religion show[s] very low numbers in terms of papers as well as mentions" [1]. There is a stream of writing on spirituality in HCI for at least two decades, some of which overtly deals with religious or spiritual themes, such as: Wyche et al [8], Buie, Blythe et al [9],[10], Abokhodir et al [11], Yarosh et al [12] Woodruff et al [13] and Hammer [15]. There are CHI conversations such as Muller et al [15] that discuss spirituality even though they do not openly address it in the title of the work. There is also non-fiction on HCI and alternate philosophies like Bateman [17]. Yet the size of this valuable core of work is still small, and relatively marginal, compared the expanse of HCI as a whole. It would also be useful to assess what impact this stream has had on HCI training, and what steps could be taken to bring it forward.

An informal poll (n>200) at the online UX conference "Behaviour and Design" in 2020 elicited over 98% response of "Agree" or "Strongly Agree" to the statement: "More emphasis on learning to be aware of one's own thoughts, emotions and attitudes should be given in Human Centred Design training". The author fielded it in the context of his talk on how Vedantic psychology can support mental health when doing humanitarian UX [2]. The intensity of the response, along with the follow up conversations springing out of the conference, indicate there is a hunger to be able to work deeply and effectively with our own mind and emotions. A handful of early-career HCI practitioners reached out subsequently, expressing a wish to combine their background in spirituality with their day-job in HCI. But they felt somewhat unsupported by standard HCI curriculums, and unsure of how to proceed. This paper aims to describe some of the principles in the Gita as a way to address this need.

1.6 The Bhagavad Gita and the Spiritual Path

Let us clarify the elements of the Gita, and related topics, that we will not cover: it is not assumed the reader does, or should, follow the Gita. Rather, a distilled form of some of the underlying principles will be discussed, specifically as to how they – and HCI – can be mutually supportive. Translated extracts from the Gita [18], its commentaries and teachings of its major exponents will be given [19], but there is no reference to religious rituals and customs, life-after-death or cosmology. It should also be noted that there are aspects of Indian spirituality that can only be practiced after a specific initiation (such as most of *Tantra* [20] or caste-specific Vedic rituals) but there is no such limit on practicing the three Yogas. It is taught openly around the world. Nor does this paper claim to present a full picture of the Vedantic philosophy which runs through the Gita. Nor does it focus on the presentations of the Gita that are intended for religious communities, such as those by Srila Prabhupada [5]. Neither does it attempt a comparative study between its philosophy and those underlying HCI – though that is a valuable discussion which, happily, the CHI community is making space for [18].

Now let's move on to the main aspects of the Gita we will look at. The Gita asserts there is an enduring aspect to what we are –

called in Sanskrit *Atman*, which is translated various as the Self, Soul or Consciousness. This Self is considered fundamentally pure, akin to the way the sky is unsullied by whatever shape of cloud floats through it. Additionally it is traditionally described with three terms: *Sat*, *Chit*, *Ananda* – or true (in the sense of being bedrock reality), conscious and naturally blissful. Again, "true" in this sense is akin to how the sky is the underlying reality to whatever shapes we see in the clouds.

This *Atman* is to be recognized, and the recognition to gradually permeate one's life. The Gita can be read both theistically and non-theistically (impersonalism), and those two approaches meet in the Gita: a closer relationship with the *Atman* implies both a closer relationship with who we really are, and also with the Divine. Different commentarial traditions diverge around this point, but that is outside our current scope.

This paper treads lightly around issues of describing God too closely, as the language of the Gita is very fluid, misunderstandings can easily emerge, such as the "Protestant bias" where we interpret sacred texts of other traditions as though they were their equivalent to the Bible [23], or "postmodernist bias" where we take any description of the Divine to be mere opinion, suspect, and reflecting a particular group's power narrative [23]. The character of Lord Krishna flows between being a human actor (Arjuna's charioteer), the entire universe ("Cosmic Form"), the impersonal inner light of the soul as perceived in meditation (*Brahman*), the essence of the soul within every creature (*Paramatman*) and the personal God as experienced in the heart of the devotee (*Bhagavan*). This multiplicity is a characteristic of Hinduism [19], and it is outside of the scope of this paper to explicate it. For our purposes, the main point is that there are multiple ways to approach spirituality, depending on one's proclivities. This multidimensionality is part of the charm of the Gita, and the author intentionally does not try to pin it down. The three main Yogas to be discussed shortly reflect this diversity. We will turn to the Gita itself and explanatory words by a major modern teacher of the Gita, Mata "Amma" Amritanandamayi (called henceforth "Amma"):

"He who is free from malice towards all, is friendly and compassionate towards all beings, free from the feelings of "I" and "mine" even-minded in pain and pleasure, forgiving, ever content, steady in meditation, self-controlled and possessed of firm conviction, with mind and intellect fixed on Me – that devotee of Mine, is dear to me". (BG 12.13-14) [18]

"All paths [karma, bhakti, jnana] lead to the same goal, and all paths incorporate devotion or love as essential to the practice." [23]

"All yogas aim at *samatva bhava* (attitude of equality). What is known as yoga is *samatva*. There is no God beyond that, whatever may be the path. That state should be attained." [23]

"Any spiritual path, whichever it may be, involves renunciation. Without practising renunciation, the desired benefit will not be obtained." [23]

"Whatever the path is, *sadhana* [disciplined practice] should be performed and should be known through experience." [23]

1.7 The Three Main Yogas in the Bhagavad Gita

It is worth clarifying that Yoga here does not refer to physical exercises or postures. Instead it indicates a way of joining two things. The English word “yoke” – as in yoking two oxen – is an etymological descendent. The Gita gives three main perspectives on this yoking. In order of appearance, the first is Karma Yoga. This “Path of Action” emphasizes selfless service and hands-on work for the greater good, but done without being attached to the outcome. This informs issues around HCI for good. Secondly is Bhakti Yoga. This “Path of Devotion” emphasizes feeling reverence and love and seeking out the presence of the Divine. This paper focuses on seeing the Beloved in others, and thus informs issues of relationship with participants. Thirdly is Jnana Yoga (pronounced “gyan”), the “Path of Knowledge” which uses skillful reasoning to support a meditative introspection, which enables one to see directly into questions like “Who am I?”. This informs HCI issues around understanding one’s perceptions, bias and identity. There are other forms of Yoga beyond these, such as Raja Yoga that deals with technical aspects of meditation. These are somewhat specialized and thus not discussed in this paper.

The Gita, like many Hindu scriptures, is set as a dialogue in a moment of high dramatic tension. It has its own language and style, including the use of “He”. This is not meant to exclude people identifying otherwise. Again, a focus of the Gita is to put demographic (read: temporary) differences into perspective against the background of the enduring, blissful consciousness.

1.8 Common Ground: Facing Death, Contemplating Justice, In a Beautiful, Dangerous and Complex World

Given that we live in fragile bodies in a dangerous world, and realistically this day might be our last, how should we approach our HCI work today? Situating ourselves in this question places us on common ground with the characters in the Gita. Awareness of our mortality, and the imminence of death, brings into relief the meaning our life might have.

The dialogue is set in the middle of a battlefield, between two armies, moments before they start fighting. Arjuna faces an intense dilemma at the start, as he is caught between various ways of understanding how justice should be established. Lives are at stake, both for his family and his nation. Light crackles around the *Astra* missiles that both sides aim at each other. He has friends, family and teachers on both sides. Truth and deceit mix in unpredictable ways. He turns to Sri Krishna for advice. It is a raw, highly charged scene set in a complex, beautiful and dangerous world. Similarities to our modern world are striking, especially at the time of writing in November 2020.

Facing death is a principle theme in the Gita. A thought experiment: on your deathbed, what will you look back and value about the time spent in HCI research? What is there – if anything – in HCI that imbues your life with meaning? What aspects of your practice will you consider effort well spent?

The topic of death does arise in HCI literature, but mostly in indirect ways such as technology for end-of-life and bereavement scenarios [28, 29]. Yet in these cases it is other people who are dying. The author has not yet found in HCI literature, nor in his years

of HCI training, a full-frontal treatment of the question: what will my HCI matter to me near the end of *my* life? Yet the Gita asks its reader to consider this.

2 KARMA YOGA AND HCI

“Therefore, remaining unattached, always do the action worthy of performance. Engaging in action truly unattached, man attains the supreme. By action alone, indeed, Janaka and others gained perfection. Moreover, even looking to the welfare of the world, you should perform action.” (BG 3.19-20)

Reducing physical discomfort through good ergonomics, mental confusion through usability, differently-abled exclusion through accessibility: these and many other aspects of regular HCI practice demonstrably solve real problems for real people. Over recent years the discussions around #chi4good have increased to being a topline focus for CHI. “We have noticed a recent rhetorical trend in HCI publications and in the pubs at CHI: A lot of people want to focus their work on ‘doing good,’ ‘making a difference,’ or ‘being inspiring.’” [30]. Because poorly designed technology can harm vulnerable people, and well-conceived technology can alleviate suffering, HCI is a genuine way to work for good [31–33]. Yet despite good intentions, and especially when focused on the intense suffering in most humanitarian initiatives, it is easy to become burned out, frustrated, experience “compassion fatigue” and even trauma. We may inadvertently do more harm than good [34, 35]. Karma Yoga offers help on these points.

2.1 Unattached to the Fruit of Action

One provocative addition the Gita offers is that we become more detached from the interim results. The poetic language used is to be “unattached to the fruits”. The underlying principle here that we can do our best work but there is no guarantee of the desired outcome. Maintaining a detached attitude allows us to weather the unavoidable ups and downs. It allows a more peaceful attitude, and this enables better work. By contrast, being overly attached to the outcomes creates anxiety, which over the course of time supports burnout and illness. The ability to accept the situation presented to us, moment by moment, allows a more accurate view and thus supports effective response. The inability to accept things-as-they-are suggests an emotional turbulence that may inhibit effective action. Even while focused on attaining a positive outcome, we will make better progress if we are aware – yet not fixated – on the ups and downs of our progress. This is particularly relevant when we are working in complex and broken situations, as is the case with much humanitarian work.

“If seeds are sown, they may or may not sprout. If there is no rain, you can dig wells and get water for irrigation; but however much you try, you cannot say for sure how good the harvest will be. Just before the harvest, a great storm or a flood could destroy the entire crop. This is the nature of the world. If we can accept this, we can live without sorrow. This is why Sri Krishna said, ‘Perform your work. The result is in God’s hands. Do not worry about it!’”. (Amma in ‘Eternal Truth’ [19] p.75)

“As the unwise act out of their attachment to action, O Bharata, so should the wise act, but without any attachment, desiring the welfare of the world” (BG 3.25)

“One who is free from attachment, non-egoistic, endowed with firmness and vigour and unaffected by success or failure, is called *sattvic*. He who is full of passion attached to the fruits of action, oppressive, malignant, impure, easily elated or dejected, is called *rajasic*” (BG 18.36-37)

2.2 Reducing Selfishness and Self-Centeredness

A second challenge the Gita poses to us is to work with less selfishness. The term “selfless” is used in commentaries, but this can be troubling. It does not mean self-punishment, unworthiness or a shadowy faux-humility. Those attitudes are still self-centered, albeit presenting in a different way than conventional arrogance. Nor does it mean timid meekness - on the contrary, Sri Krishna continually urges Arjuna to move forward boldly. It is better understood simply as loosening of selfishness motives. The folk phrase “There’s no ‘I’ in ‘Team’” points to this meaning. How do we loosen selfish motives? We have touched on two simple but effective ways already. Firstly, reflect on one’s inevitable death and what really matters. Secondly, get engaged with helping other people and focus on what they need.

A further meaning of reducing selfishness emerges in the commentarial tradition: intentionally deflate one’s own trips about being more virtuous, clever, educated, important, beautiful, popular or generally more worthy than others. Note that we do not try to replace a sense of “I’m so great” with “I’m so worthless”. Rather, since we are focused on helping other people who are suffering, we find we gradually forget about either notion. “Usually, people work to fulfil their selfish desires. However, when we perform an action even for a short while without expecting anything in return, it purifies our mind.” [26]

There is an additional level to the understanding of selflessness. A traditional image that points to this level of interpretation is that if one hand is in pain, the other will naturally move to soothe it. There is no question of one hand owing the other a favor. They are not separate, and there is no ground for one hand to – as it were – have an ego trip about its benevolence. This understanding “beyond the pairs of opposites” runs through the Gita, and the practice of Karma Yoga results in the ability to understand it more directly. We will see the same theme return in the other two Yogas as well.

“Satisfied with whatever comes unasked, beyond the pairs of opposites, free from envy, balanced in success and failure, even though acting, he is not bound” (BG 4.22)

3 BHAKTI YOGA

3.1 Love Through Understanding

“Oh Arjuna, the best type of yogi is he who feels for others, whether in grief or pleasure, even as he feels for himself”. (BG 6.32)

HCI combines strengths with Bhakti Yoga through the act of engaging with someone in the spirit of curiosity, positive regard and warmth. From the perspective of HCI, this is important for quality of research, for ethical research relationships, and for counteracting prejudice. From the spiritual perspective in Bhakti Yoga, our lives are well spent when we see a fundamental wonderful-lovability in creation, and work to serve it joyfully.

A simple line of self-assessment questions can help identify the mood of Bhakti: is our research practice causing us to develop more reverence – or more jadedness – with life? More acceptance and appreciation of people, or more anxiety and animosity? Are we, year on year, seeing some uptick in how much beauty we experience through our work? Bhakti Yoga deals with increasing the sense of beauty and love in our relationship with creation.

HCI research conducted through personal interaction – such as interviews or workshops – involves deeply watching, listening and feeling. A warm, positive and accepting attitude creates a sense of safety that allows people to open up and reveal themselves. When I train practitioners, I suggest a rule of thumb that their participants should leave their session feeling appreciated, and feel they have done us a favor by being there. Yet this is undoubtedly hard, especially in a long day of testing, where the researcher may be running back to back sessions, wrestling with temperamental equipment, as well as fire-fighting unrelated issues via email and chat. We may have the intention to be our most welcoming and attentive selves for each participant, but the reality is that we may be taciturn and impatient. Participants might feel strip-mined more than loved.

3.2 Fundamental Goodness

The Gita acknowledges that people are complex with mixed motivations, but are fundamentally good. The “Self” (*Atman*) – their fundamental identity, beneath all temporary clothing such as body, emotion and thought – is conscious, blissful and solidly-real (Skt. *Chit, Ananda, Sat*). Two explanatory metaphors used in commentaries are: different ornaments may be made from gold but despite difference in name and form they remain gold. And: trees in the forest may have grown straight and tall, or short and crooked, but they are fundamentally appreciable as trees. Salient to our point, it is observed that when we walk in the forest we can take delight in the sheer variety of trees. Accepting them all as they are, the sheer range is itself a source of unfolding joy. Delight in the variegated nature of creation (for trees, read: people) is a hallmark of Bhakti Yoga.

“It is, in fact, the one Supreme Principle that has transformed itself into all those forms. So, in Hinduism everything is God. There is nothing that is not God. Hinduism teaches us to love and serve animals, birds, reptiles, trees, plants, mountains, rivers – everything, even a deadly, poisonous cobra.” ([19] p6)

“I am the wholesome fragrance exuding from the earth; the luminescence of fire am I; the life in all creatures” (BG 7.9)

“Also, I am seated in the heart of all beings” (BG 15.15)

“Those who constantly meditate on Me as not separate from beings, worship me in all beings, to them I give full protection and fulfil their needs” (BG 9.22)

This paper proposes that it becomes easier to treat people with curiosity, acceptance and positive regard if we intentionally consider them as being – at heart – something fundamentally pure and positive. Conversely, it becomes easier to see others as sparks of the divine if we treat them with acceptance and positive regard. They are mutually reinforcing. The virtuous cycle creates a sense of bliss and reverence, which supports positive outcomes such as emotional health and meaningfulness.

3.3 Antidote to Prejudice

Taking a stance that everyone is worthy of love (because everyone is fundamentally good) is an antidote to prejudice and hate. This is not to be confused with a soft blanket philosophy in which faults are ignored because it is uncomfortable. The complexities of right and wrong action are a major topic in the Gita, and the characters are nothing if not complex. The assertion of people’s fundamental goodness is no refusal to acknowledge negative behavior. On the contrary, it provides a background against which the spectrum of human behavior can be seen more clearly. In the analogy of gold ornaments, it affirms that all ornaments are good because they are made of gold (their fundamental nature); it is not saying they are good because they are all nice shapes (their relative nature). This concept of “equal vision” (Skt. *samatva bhava*) – the ability to see beyond apparent differences and thus see beings equally – is core to Gita’s message.

“The humble sages, by virtue of true knowledge, see with equal vision a learned and gentle priest, a cow, an elephant, a dog and a dog-eater.” (BG 5.20)

“That by which the one imperishable existence is perceived, undivided and equally present, in all beings, know that knowledge to be *sattvic* [harmonious]. But that knowledge which sees in all being various entities of distinct kinds as different from one another, know that knowledge as *rajasic* [dynamic yet imbalanced]” (BG 18.20-21)

Contrast this view with any approach that takes a demographic category as the principal determinant of worth. Ethnicity, gender, sexuality, class, tribal history, political affiliation – these may be important factors that influence our research, such as our recruiting criteria. Ensuring a broad, inclusive and accurate representation of our end-users is fundamental for good research. Giving special consideration where it is needed is positive, but favoritism is not. We should be extremely cautious about instituting new prejudices to counteract old ones. For example, in a focus group, being overly solicitous towards someone perceived to be from a historically disadvantaged minority, such as insisting a black woman speak first (whether she wants to or not). A naïve countermeasure to a historical prejudice is unlikely to bring out the best response from the group. The way in which it can create turbulence is a meaning of *rajasic* in the above quotation (BG 18.21).

People are more than their demographics. People are an *Atman* – a soul, a Self, a consciousness that is inherently blissful and enduringly and solidly real. This is a profound basis on which to exercise

our best efforts of curiosity, unconditional positive regard and acceptance. Though we do not directly perceive it in normal waking consciousness (in which we function as researchers) we do see it sparkling through. We can take delight in these little details: the glimmer of humor in someone’s eye, the distinctive way they hold a pen, how their thoughts connect in surprising ways, the depth of feeling they express, and of course the quirky ways they use technology. Appreciating these moments of beauty enriches both our HCI work and our spiritual life. Another short spiritual text based around a dialogue is “The Prophet” by Khalil Gibran, whose “Speak to us of Work” captures the mood of Bhakti Yoga and Karma Yoga together:

“And what is it to work with love? It is to weave the cloth with threads drawn from your heart, even as if your beloved were to wear that cloth.” [36]

4 JNANA YOGA

“As the one sun illumines all this world, so does He who abides in the field, O Arjuna, illumines the whole field. Those who see with eyes of knowledge the difference between the body and the knower of the body, and can also understand the process of liberation from bondage in material nature, attain to the supreme goal.” (BG 13.34-35)

4.1 Attentive, Open Awareness

HCI and Jnana Yoga (pronounced *gyana* yoga) come together over issues where we need to make our mind calm and spacious to observe the workings of emotion, thought, perception and identity. Jnana Yoga deals with the question “Who am I?”. Whereas Bhakti Yoga affirmed the individual is a spark of the divine, Jnana yoga mostly proceeds through a process of negation. It is the most introspective and internal of the three Yogas. It does require some fluency in making the mind and emotions calm, which is likened to a pool of water becoming clear to its bottom. It also requires a sense of wakeful awareness, without judgement, and in the mood of merely being a neutral witness. Thus a nap on the sofa may calm the mind, but it is not a basis for this Yoga because it lacks the quality of wakefulness. Nor is a session of impassioned soul-searching Jnana Yoga, because it lacks the quality of calm, neutral detachment. Though this state is not easy to find and maintain, it is closely related to a type of attention we need to use when observing participants: attentive, calm, open minded and uninvolved.

HCI practice requires detecting and intuiting people’s views, moods, motivations, cognitive styles and mental models. From a visceral emotional reaction to a new product, to a feeling about an online communication, to the meaning they give to a symbol, to the way they learn, and even the subtleties of their styles of thinking [37] – there is a tremendously broad range of internal processes an HCI researcher may need to understand. This gives an opportunity to train the type of neutral, attentive and panoramic awareness that is then developed in Jnana Yoga. And conversely, Jnana Yoga directly develops the power of calm, attentive, neutral observation.

4.2 Distinguishing the Temporary and Enduring

A gift of HCI research is the chance to observe a great variety of people. In Bhakti Yoga (above) this supports a delight in the sheer variety. In Jnana Yoga, this supports the understanding of how provisional (not fixed) are people's patterns of physicality, thought and emotion. In the spirit of "*plus ça change*", the more we detect the shifting cloudscape of people's temporary nature, the more opportunity to be aware of the underlying space in which these dwell. This ability to focus in on the underlying space, or underlying substratum, is much of the work of Jnana Yoga.

"These bodies are known to have an end; the dweller in the body is eternal, imperishable, infinite." (BG 2.18)

"As the all-pervading Akasha (space), because of its subtlety, is not tainted, so the Self, existent everywhere, though dwelling in the body, is not tainted" (BG 13.33)

The *Atman* is variously likened to space, to a sun, to the "dweller" or "knower of the "field" of the body-mind-emotions. It is also described as the substratum, since it functions like the bedrock of our existing as people.

4.3 Awareness of Bias and Mental Health

Whatever our position on the nature of bias in researchers, we may agree that growing a mature, self-reflective awareness is an important part counteracting any negative effects. If, through mental tranquility, we can see our own psychological processes with – as it were – a higher frame rate and in higher resolution, then we have a better chance to understand directly how our personal patterning functions.

In terms of mental health, Amma frequently mentions in public talks that physical health relies on the ability for the body to move, whereas mental health relies on the mind having a chance to be still. Jnana Yoga allows thoughts to settle, and this stillness may have a revivifying effect on the psyche.

"The knowledge of the Absolute removes ignorance and reveals everything, just like the shining sun removes darkness and lights up everything" (BG 5.16)

"Truly there is in this world nothing so purifying as knowledge; he who is perfected in Yoga of himself in time finds this within himself" (BG 4.38)

5 CONCLUSION

5.1 Supporting an Integrated Approach to an HCI Career

There is a hunger to have more resources for working with one's own attitudes and emotions, and with the "inner game" of being an HCI practitioner. People may also feel a need to "be oneself" at work, such that one's career and one's spiritual life can support each other, and they do not feel split. For some people, doing their best work will require overtly considering it in the light of a spiritual worldview. This paper has suggested multiple approaches, based on the three main Yogas of the Bhagavad Gita, where HCI practice dovetails with spiritual practice, in a mutually reinforcing way.

The Bhagavad Gita offers a rich set of insights and practices, in the form of text and commentaries, as well as modelled by teachers who embody the principles it contains. There is no need to convert in order to try the principles in practice: the tradition offers the guidance freely, and encourages us to make use of it. It is open-ended, experiential and inclusive by nature. The author humbly acknowledges this paper has only been able to briefly touch on many points that deserve a much deeper explanation. He hopes more qualified practitioners will speak up and support this initiative.

Given the intensity of social and environmental change, being an HCI practitioner in this third decade of the century is likely to be challenging. The HCI field has matured and aims to apply technology wisely, which raises questions about ethics, justice, the natural world and – dare we say it? – the meaning of life.

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A COMMENTARY

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The paper imagines and attempts to lay out a new philosophical ground for HCI, leveraging ideas contained in the Bhagavad Gita, one of the main holy scriptures for Hinduism. To take centuries of heterogeneous and contested philosophy and attempt to draw lessons for a research field that, while being new, is also heterogeneous (or perhaps attempting to be one) and contested, is an ambitious undertaking. We appreciate that this submission demonstrates an increased interest from global HCI scholars in engaging with cultures different from their own. However, there are sensitivities that must be considered in such engagement, and this informs our hesitation to recommend this submission for publication at this time.

First, our positionality. In this joint review, Naveen writes from the perspective of a born Hindu Savarna (dominant caste), who is becoming aware of the harms and oppressions that Hindu philosophies and practices foster, particularly when considered as a monolithic framework. Neha reviews from the perspective of being born and brought up in a Hindu (Savarna) family in India, and having read multiple interpretations of the Gita, and teachings of Swami Vivekananda, Ramakrishna Paramhansa, and others that inform her reading. We have a shared concern around this paper being the first (to our knowledge) introduction to Hinduism, yoga, and the Gita to the HCI community. From these standpoints, and given the risks associated with this being the first such paper on these topics that could inform the basis of understanding for HCI-situated readers, we disagree with what the paper is advocating for the field of HCI, which we believe has harmful implications, as well as how the paper makes its argument.

The author's own positionality is unclear but critical to clarify. This is not necessarily to question authority or defend the paper's focus, but to explain how the author came upon this area of interest as a scholarly pursuit, and what made them make the choices they did around the framing of the piece. Such a statement would help to re-examine how the author's identity brings them to produce this work with their unique perspective into Hinduism and yoga, and differently than another author might. It would also help the reader understand whether the paper is written with the intent to focus on culture, religion, spirituality, history, mythology, theology, or all of the above? In the long term, this will help to situate the work among what we expect to be a growing body of HCI scholarship engaging with religion and faith. It may also assist the author to more clearly frame their contributions to this growing field as their career progresses.

On knowledge sources being cited. The author cites one version of the Gita in this work, but there are numerous, and each one

gets the message across differently, with different sects following different texts. We would like the paper to then be extremely clear that they are writing about *one* reading of the Gita, and one reading only. And each other reading might be ever so slightly (or greatly) different. There are also many lines in the paper that should be accompanied with cites, but are not. "Don Norman's call to revivify the humanistic and spiritual elements of design needs practical steps" in 6.2 does not have a cite. This is just one example, and there are several throughout the paper. Further, the space allotted to discussing karma yoga is also quite limited, and it is unclear where some of the knowledge presented in this paper is coming from.

A critical analysis of the different implications of the teachings of the Gita seems essential. The paper does not engage with critical perspectives on Gita [1, 2, 4] that have established how the very fundamental ideas postulated in the Gita, e.g. karma, is the root of the occupational caste / jaati system, which continues even in the most "progressive" spaces of India as well as the U.S. (e.g. the case of caste-based discrimination in Cisco Systems Inc. [3]). This lack of criticality leads to arguments that can be harmful to the ongoing discourse of ethics and social justice within and around HCI. For example, the paper's inference for HCI in the section on Bhakti yoga overlooks the fundamental notion of power and justice. The passage reads, "We should be extremely cautious about instituting new prejudices to counteract old ones. For example, in a focus group, being overly solicitous towards someone perceived to be from a historically disadvantaged minority, such as insisting a black woman speak first (whether she wants to or not)...." The passage seems to align with the idea of maintaining the race, gender, and caste status quo because of a belief in a fundamental idea that all lives are equal. This can derail years of hard work by feminist researchers within HCI that centres how power acts and has to be accounted for in the research and design of technology. Furthermore, there are other established ways we can draw from, for example, participatory action research, to figure out if a particular human being who happens to be, e.g., a Black woman wants to speak and how, rather than assuming a power position as a researcher to determine who speaks first.

Another example of an uncritical reading of the Gita is this claim that the paper makes: "there is no such limit on practicing the three Yogas. It is taught openly around the world." The question arises as to by whom and how it is taught, and who has the privilege to learn and practice these three yogas? Do the Dalits in India and elsewhere have socially constructed privileges to learn, practice and teach the three yogas? This passage borders on whitewashing of the ways in which some of the ideas of the Gita have manifested in the everyday lives of over a billion people. The extrapolation of the Hindu religion to "Indian spirituality" is problematic, and aligns with the ongoing push to oust and oppress communities of other religions and castes in India. Especially given the mention of Krishna, it cannot be said that this paper is not about religion. But

then some of the most complex aspects of religion, e.g. caste issues, that are playing out as we speak, cannot be overlooked.

Without a complete understanding, concepts in the paper can be misunderstood and misappropriated. E.g. in 6.3 the author talks about "develop[ing] our own perspective through personal experience". Yes, but what might this bring forth from a person who does not yet fully grasp what is meant by developing one's perspective through personal experience? It can be confusing, but also dangerous if everyone might exercise freedom to develop their own perspective and act accordingly, without attending to potential harm that might be done in the process. Theories of social justice speak to this point around taking responsibility for one's actions. We are not saying the author advocates that we don't, but that the explanation is at present incomplete. Next, there is the question of what HCI will matter at the end of my life? Well, if a naive understanding leads one to "nothing" then where does that leave us?

We will stop here, and ask forgiveness if we have been too harsh. We do not see a problem with these topics being introduced to the HCI community, and for thought to be given to how they might shape HCI practice. But this work is far from complete, and this is why we express our hesitation regarding its readiness for publication at this time, along with offering specific points where a deeper, more comprehensive reading would do far more of a service for the CHI community who, given that this introduces a new topic, deserve a well-rounded resource. It must acknowledge the vastness of Hindu/Vedanta philosophy, and what the Gita is (in its multiplicity of interpretations). It must articulate the difference between religion and spirituality, and reflect critically on how these are constantly being conflated, and how religion is being continually misused, in the very context that the author is drawing from. The arguments offered must engage with questions around power, as well as the complex and often oppressive ways the Gita has been used historically and contemporaneously by majority Hindus.

While we are not opposed to this topic entering, challenging, and diversifying the predominantly Western- and Euro-centric discourse in the HCI community, we also offer our positionality and situated knowledges, and highlight the complexity and nuance of the subject that may be missed when reading it with that same hegemonic lens. In this commentary, we have also tried to illustrate what risks can arise if misappropriation occurs, even if well-intentioned. For this reason, we recommend that the author give this piece more time and space to develop.

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